

Stengel counting on Siebern to end club's left field woes

By JIM OGLE

ST. PETERSBURG, Fla., Feb. 23 — Almost lost amid the mass of youngsters desperately trying to impress people in the Yankee instructional school is the man Casey Stengel hopes will end the Yankees' left field worries.

Norm Siebern, after a brilliant year in Denver, is back with more experience, more determination and is expected to fill a pressing need. Stengel has long lamented his inability to find a major league leftfielder and believes he has lost many a ball game in that spot.

Charlie Keller filled that spot capably for several years. Gene Woodling was the next capable guardian of that terrain, then Irv Noren did a good job until his legs folded up on him. Ever since, however, there has been a procession of left fielders with none answering the need.

Two years ago Siebern, after two years in service, was the standout in the rookie school and seemed certain to open the season in left field. During the exhibition season, however, he ran into a wall at Al Lang Field and fractured a kneecap.

After months of recuperating he started to play in Denver, then was brought up to the Yankees. He was a disappointment with a .204 batting average. Last year he was in Denver all season and led the league in hitting (.349), runs, hits, doubles, triples and runs batted in (118).

"I feel I am ready for the major leagues now," Siebern says quietly. "Two years ago I had a bad shoulder when I reported here, then hurt my legs and was never in shape to play ball. When I played with the Yankees in 1956 I was half a ballplayer with a bad shoulder and two bad legs.

"I had been in service for two years," Norm continued. "I tried to get in shape playing winter ball, but instead hurt my shoulder. After playing all last year in Denver I feel I now have the necessary experience. I feel I can play major league ball. I realize I have the opportunity to win a regular job and this time I am physically ready to give my best."

Siebern has played in all the



Norm Siebern
He's got a job

intra-squad games, the fourth of which was held today, and Stengel has been watching him closely. Casey is interested in Siebern's base running, his aggressiveness and signs of general improvement.

"I'm very interested in that boy," Casey says. "I need a leftfielder and I am hoping he can do the job. Two years ago he showed me plenty, but when he had all that trouble it held him back. They tell me he was the best player in the minors last year."

Siebern, 23, broke into the Yankee organization in 1951 at McAlester where he hit .331 and had a perfect fielding average in 50 games. Since then he has played at Joplin, Birmingham and Denver. At Birmingham in 1953 he was voted as the best major league prospect in the Southern Association. Then came two years of army service.

Andy Cohen, who was at In-

dianapolis last year and is now manager of Denver, gives a glowing report on Siebern.

"I sure would like to have him back," Andy says, "but there isn't a chance. If he isn't a major league outfielder, then I have never seen one. He was by far the best hitter in the Association last year and I don't mean just on average. He is a good solid hitter, hits where the ball is pitched and doesn't swing at bad pitches."

Around mid-season last year Siebern, who had always been a spray type hitter, started to pull the ball and wound up with 24 home runs, his top total.

"I am not strictly a pull hitter," Siebern says. "I started out in Birmingham trying to pull, but was not too successful. I wasn't trying to pull last year, but suddenly began to hit to right field. I still hit where the ball is pitched, but I can get good power to right."

Andy Carey called Lee MacPhail collect from Malibu Beach, Calif., this morning and accepted terms. "He got close to what he wanted," MacPhail said.

Bob Turley, Johnny Kucks, Bob Grim, Tom Sturdivant and Tommy Byrne are still outside the fold and MacPhail didn't even talk to any of them today. Sturdy is expected in tomorrow.

Intra-squad games are on tap tomorrow and Tuesday. Then the rookies will disappear although a couple, including Deron Johnson, will be held over for the regular spring training.

Casey Stengel was a bit under the weather and dressed early, then watched a couple of innings from a car back of the batting cage.

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